

Chapter 113-1

Liang Shi was teased by Xu Qingzhu until she didn't know what to do.

She turned her hand to grip Xu Qingzhu's hand tightly, gave a low cough, and changed the subject. "I'm a bit hungry."

Xu Qingzhu said, "Let's go eat then."

After saying this, she withdrew her hand from Liang Shi's palm and got out of the car first.

The wind was too strong, blowing the strands of hair scattered on either side of Xu Qingzhu's cheeks into disarray. She reached up to tuck them behind her ear, looking as if nothing had just happened.

Liang Shi grabbed the coat from the back seat for her, locked the car, and then handed her the clothes.

Xu Qingzhu casually draped it over herself.

In the afternoon, no matter how cold the weather was, there was a limit. Even in Haizhou City, which was about to enter winter, it wasn't as if the sun had been swallowed up and temperatures had plunged below zero.

Besides, it was just a short walk, so Liang Shi let her be.

But she still pulled the coat tighter around her.

With the cold autumn wind blowing, the heat in Liang Shi's body finally subsided somewhat.

Having just been teased by Xu Qingzhu until her heart was restless, those romantic thoughts had all dispersed. But when they went in to order, her fingers landed on the menu—slightly reddish, slender and fair—and she suddenly felt her ears grow hot again.

She simply handed the menu to Xu Qingzhu. "You order."

Thus relinquishing the initiative.

Xu Qingzhu didn't stand on ceremony with her either, efficiently ordering several dishes. Only after the server left the private room did she take off her coat, revealing the white fitted base layer underneath. Tight clothing would accentuate her figure more.

A curve rising from flatness was hard to ignore.

What's more, Xu Qingzhu's figure was very beautiful.

When buying lingerie online, you'd always see the models' photos, but none were as beautiful as Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi had almost gotten a lingerie advertisement endorsement before. She had specifically trained for a period of time for it and had done quite well, comparing herself in many ways. But unexpectedly, that endorsement was taken by a rival.

As someone who had witnessed such beautiful scenery¹, even through clothes, it was hard for her mind to remain pure again.

Especially since just a few hours ago, she had accidentally opened Xu Qingzhu's wardrobe.

And just minutes ago, Xu Qingzhu had steered the conversation in that direction with her words.

Liang Shi simply lowered her eyes and stopped looking, trying to breathe lightly to calm her restless emotions.

Inside the Japanese-style private room, the wooden table lay between Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu. The natural wood color made the entire space appear gentle and bright.

Neither Liang Shi nor Xu Qingzhu spoke.

Xu Qingzhu was handling work matters on her phone, while Liang Shi kept her head down, trying to chase those romantic thoughts out of her mind.

It was also strange. In the past, she had been someone her assistant described as absurdly zen²—a proper gentleman who never had inappropriate behaviors or thoughts when filming with fellow actors.

But in front of Xu Qingzhu, she seemed to always break her principles.

It was hard to say what kind of behavior this was.

She even vaguely felt that she was being indecent.

But if you were to say she was truly indecent, her imagination was limited only to things they had done before and sights she had seen—there weren't any more fantasies beyond that.

Even in her dreams, they only revolved around scenes that had already happened, never daring to develop further.

This kind of emotion was really hard to fathom and grasp.

When Xu Qingzhu finished replying to messages and put her phone on the table, she finally noticed that Liang Shi's gaze had fallen on some unknown place, lost in thought about who knows what.

And her ears were red.

Xu Qingzhu propped her chin on one hand and looked at Liang Shi, her gaze burning.

After a long while, Liang Shi sensed the gaze and suddenly raised her head, meeting Xu Qingzhu's interested eyes.

Their eyes met. Xu Qingzhu's eyes were full of teasing as she smiled faintly. "Teacher Liang, what are you thinking about?"

It was clearly a perfectly normal question, but falling on Liang Shi's ears, no matter how she heard it, it seemed to carry some indescribable meaning.

Liang Shi picked up the chopsticks beside her, fiddling with them in her hands to ease her inner embarrassment.

"Nothing." Liang Shi denied.

Xu Qingzhu didn't ask further, just drew out her voice: "Oh~"

This tone was even more suggestive than before.

Just then, the server came in to serve the dishes, relieving some of Liang Shi's embarrassment.

The dishes were quickly served in full, filling the entire table.

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1. "霁月風光" (jì yuè fēng guāng) literally means "clear moon scenery," but here it's a euphemism referring to having seen Xu Qingzhu's body/intimate moments. ⇐
 2. "佛系" (fó xì) literally means "Buddhist-style" and is modern Chinese slang describing someone who is very calm, detached, and doesn't get worked up about things—essentially going with the flow without strong desires or reactions. ⇐

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The servers wearing kimonos all retreated, and the natural wood-colored door was slid shut. Xu Qingzhu held her chopsticks and poked around in a dish, though it looked more like she was poking at air.

Liang Shi breathed a sigh of relief. "Let's eat."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her. After a moment, she let down her hair, then extended her wrist—on it was a black hair tie. "Come tie my hair for me, okay?"

She used a questioning tone, those clear eyes looking at Liang Shi.

No one could refuse Xu Qingzhu like this.

Liang Shi put down the chopsticks in her hand, got up and walked over to her side, half-kneeling on one knee behind her. She used her ten fingers like a comb to stroke through her fine, soft hair, making sure every strand was smooth.

Because she had tied her hair so many times before, everything was familiar and effortless.

She quickly finished tying her hair—three loops, loosening it a bit at the tail so it wouldn't pull on the scalp too much.

Xu Qingzhu really did have a lot of hair. Without any curls or perms, just her naturally fine and soft hair was already a handful when grabbed.

Her hair was so smooth that when Liang Shi was handling it, a few strands would always slip away.

Liang Shi liked the texture of her hair. After tying it, she always habitually stroked it once, and this time was no different.

She ran her hand over the top of her head like petting a cat, then hooked her fingers in the ends of her hair, letting them slip away silently.

"Done." Liang Shi said and was about to leave, but Xu Qingzhu brought her utensils over. "Just eat over here."

Liang Shi was momentarily stunned. Seeing that the table was long enough, she didn't refuse. "Okay."

The two sat side by side. Xu Qingzhu still propped her chin on one hand, looking sideways at her.

Being watched like this made Liang Shi somewhat embarrassed. She had picked up some food but hadn't brought it to her mouth yet. Looking at Xu Qingzhu's gaze, she couldn't help but ask, "What is it?"

Xu Qingzhu licked her lips, and instantly they glistened.

The cold sunlight from outside refracted through the glass, appearing gentle and beautiful.

On that usually cold and indifferent face hung a faint smile. "Are you going to eat now?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Mm."

"You're not eating?" Liang Shi asked back.

She couldn't quite figure out what Xu Qingzhu was going to do.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu suddenly leaned toward her, abruptly closing in, her warm breath landing on Liang Shi's face.

Xu Qingzhu said, "I am eating."

"Is the food not to your taste..." Before Liang Shi could finish speaking, Xu Qingzhu kissed her on the lips.

Her words were completely swallowed.

Liang Shi was dazed for a few seconds, then felt helpless yet amused.

But she didn't think too much about it. Her hand fell on the ends of Xu Qingzhu's hair, the fine, soft strands lightly brushing over her fingertips.

Xu Qingzhu only tasted briefly and was about to pull away when Liang Shi wrapped her arms around her waist.

Xu Qingzhu was sitting against the wall. The light yellow painted wall contrasted beautifully with the natural wood color, making it look especially warm.

The space wasn't large. Liang Shi turned her body sideways, not letting her escape.

She had been unable to hold back since they were in the car earlier, but hadn't dared to think in that direction.

Liang Shi had always been somewhat timid about these things, not daring to touch Xu Qingzhu too much without permission.

When she had desires, she would just drink another cup of tea to suppress them.

Or take a cold shower to force herself to be clear-headed.

But Xu Qingzhu was too wonderful—so wonderful that she couldn't help but drown in her.

Even knowing that there was fire ahead, she was willing to throw herself toward her.

Xu Qingzhu slowly rose to kneel, turned her body around, and then sat on Liang Shi's lap.

Liang Shi's slender legs stretched out straight, just able to pass through the gap under the wooden table.

She tried to make Xu Qingzhu sit more comfortably.

And Xu Qingzhu's hand fell on the back of her neck, then threaded through the ends of her hair. With eyes lightly closed, she devoted herself wholeheartedly to it.

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Very soon, the Japanese-style private room was filled with the scent of strawberry Baileys. Xu Qingzhu's pheromones had dispersed, richly filling Liang Shi's nostrils.

Xu Qingzhu's body had also gone soft like a puddle of water. After ending that long kiss, her chin rested on top of Liang Shi's head as she quietly adjusted her breathing.

Liang Shi's face happened to be pressed into her embrace—soft and gentle.

Liang Shi's heartbeat was in disarray, her breathing was in disarray, everything was in disarray.

Her hands had already pulled out Xu Qingzhu's base layer that had been tucked into her pants.

A section of Xu Qingzhu's waistline was exposed, with one spot showing a small patch of red where Liang Shi had pinched.

Liang Shi seemed to be particularly fond of her waist.

Xu Qingzhu's waist was very slender. Because she was so thin, her lower abdomen was flat without a trace of excess flesh. Although there wasn't much soft flesh on her waist, compared to her abdomen, it was already a spot where you could pinch a little bit of flesh.

So Liang Shi liked to pinch that little bit of flesh.

After they finished kissing, Liang Shi said in a muffled voice, "Xu Qingzhu, you need to eat more. You're too thin."

Xu Qingzhu hadn't yet emerged from the passion of moments ago. The breathing she was trying so hard to regulate suddenly became chaotic because of this sentence. Liang Shi's words made her laugh—she laughed so hard her whole body trembled, and her body swayed slightly along with it.

This made Liang Shi feel a bit stifled. Her hand patted Xu Qingzhu's back, seemingly with some annoyance. "Stop messing around."

Xu Qingzhu bent over while laughing.

It had to be said that Xu Qingzhu was very flexible. Her legs were wrapped around Liang Shi's waist.

She naturally bent forward, her hands crossed behind Liang Shi's neck, her body leaning slightly back as she looked at Liang Shi.

Those eyes held a faint smile. "Liang Shi, why are you so unromantic?"

Even the ending note was laughing.

Liang Shi: "....."

She looked at Xu Qingzhu, and it took her a while to hold back from saying—the feeling's mutual.

The words took a turn and became: "I tried my best."

Xu Qingzhu still stared at her and smiled, burying her head in the crook of her neck. "Go ahead and eat."

Liang Shi: "?"

How was she supposed to eat?

The person was still in her arms, like a little kid.

Liang Shi had never tried eating in this manner before. Just thinking about it seemed absurd.

Though she had seen couples in the honeymoon phase of their relationship on the street before, where the girl always liked to sit on the guy's lap, wanting to be held and fed, even acting spoiled asking for water.

They were both girls, and there wasn't such a big difference in their builds. In fact, when sitting side by side, Xu Qingzhu was actually a tiny bit taller than Liang Shi because of her long torso.

Eating in this way—Liang Shi had never even thought about it.

She hesitated for a moment before asking, "Aren't you going to eat?"

Xu Qingzhu rested her chin on her shoulder. "I lied to you. I already ate."

Liang Shi: "....."

How could she say "I lied to you" so casually?

But a few seconds later, Liang Shi gave a low cough and said, "I lied to you too. I also already ate."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

The two exchanged a glance, both seeing the amusement in each other's eyes.

Liang Shi patted her back. "Since we already ordered, let's eat a bit more."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I've already eaten what I wanted to eat. You go ahead."

Liang Shi: "....."

She always felt there was something in Xu Qingzhu's words, but she couldn't figure it out.

"We're really going to eat like this?" Liang Shi asked her with some uncertainty.

Xu Qingzhu held her, her head resting on her shoulder. The warm breath from her breathing made goosebumps rise on the side of Liang Shi's neck. "Can't you do it?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She decided not to bargain with Xu Qingzhu anymore.

If she bargained with a capitalist who always unconsciously steered topics in dangerous directions, she'd end up losing even her pants.

Liang Shi helplessly gave her back a light pat and said quietly, "Fine."

Chapter 113-4

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Liang Shi had challenged herself today.

She did something she would never have thought of normally—she held Xu Qingzhu while eating a meal. Although she didn't eat much, she would occasionally feed Xu Qingzhu while eating herself.

Xu Qingzhu, who was nearing her heat period, was unexpectedly clingy.

After finishing lunch, Xu Qingzhu even nestled in her arms for a while before leaving.

Although Liang Shi's body was satisfied, she couldn't help but worry in her heart.

She repeatedly reminded Xu Qingzhu to stay away from Alphas with strong pheromones, including Sally, Zhou Yi'an, and others, and to always keep suppressants on hand.

After saying all this, she asked if she had any with her. Seeing that she hadn't even brought her bag, she simply took her to a pharmacy to buy suppressants, and also bought a hot water bottle at a nearby mall.

Then she dropped her off at the company building.

As soon as Xu Qingzhu arrived downstairs at the company, she immediately transformed into a different person.

Her expression was cold and serious. She put the suppressants in her coat pocket and held the hot water bottle in her hand as if she were holding a six-figure handbag.

She told Liang Shi to drive carefully and got out of the car. Liang Shi kept watching her back, thinking she would turn around, but... she didn't.

Sure enough, Xu Qingzhu with work was not the same person as usual.

Liang Shi watched her walk into the building, then raised her hand to touch her own lips. She checked in the rearview mirror—the corner of her lip was broken.

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However, because of this lunch, Liang Shi's mood wasn't as heavy as it had been in the morning.

Instead, she felt energized, simply wanting to rescue Gu Xingyue from that cage.

As for Qi Jiao, only regret remained.

She checked the time. Because she and Xu Qingzhu had dawdled at the restaurant for so long—Xu Qingzhu had later sat on her lap playing on her phone, probably handling work matters.

Later, seeing that it was uncomfortable for her to eat, she changed to lying on her lap.

She had even taken a brief nap.

Kindergarten ended early. Because she needed to pick up Ling Dang, there wasn't enough time for Liang Shi to make a round trip to Angel Orphanage. She simply placed an order for same-city express delivery, then went to Xinhua Bookstore and bought a large pile of children's books. Only one was a novel—"The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry"¹.

She tucked the letter Gu Xingyue had given her inside "The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry" and had the courier deliver it to Gu Zhaoyuan.

At the same time, she called Gu Zhaoyuan to tell him about this.

Gu Zhaoyuan asked her if Gu Xingyue was doing well.

Liang Shi felt that simple terms like "well" or "not well" could no longer summarize Gu Xingyue's state. She could only express hope: "Anyway, things will definitely get better in the future."

Hearing this, Gu Zhaoyuan became dejected. "Alright, if there's an opportunity, please make sure to let me meet with her."

"I will." Liang Shi said, "First, read what she wrote in her letter to you. Her situation hasn't been very good recently. The family that adopted her is afraid she'll contact her former relatives, so I don't dare to rashly arrange a meeting between you two. It all depends on what she wants."

Gu Zhaoyuan expressed his understanding.

After hanging up, Liang Shi let out a breath. She took out Qi Jiao's diary from the compartment again.

Every entry was heartbreaking, the words revealing deep despair.

However, there were also entries filled with hope.

Those were when she mentioned Chen Mian.

【A new girl transferred into our class. She has shoulder-length hair. We all tie our hair in high ponytails, but only she wears her hair down. Underneath her black hair is a layer of gray. I really like that color—it's like darkness and light overlapping together. Her voice was also very pleasant when she introduced herself. Not only that, her name is also very nice. She's called—Chen Mian.】

【Chen Mian really likes painting. Like me, she doesn't like to talk much either. She's not pretty, and she doesn't stand out in a crowd. But I always secretly observe her.】

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Whenever Qi Jiao's diary mentioned Chen Mian, it was always from an observer's perspective. She recorded Chen Mian as she saw her, and also documented Chen Mian's daily life.

Qi Jiao said Chen Mian was a quiet weirdo, just like her. Although she wasn't pretty, in Qi Jiao's eyes, she was the special one.

As long as she was sitting there, Qi Jiao could only see her.

They didn't interact much in the beginning, but in the school library, the two of them met because they both reached for the same book.

It was the last copy in the library, and they had grabbed it almost simultaneously.

Qi Jiao naturally wanted to give it to her, but when she returned to the classroom, she found that book placed on her desk, while Chen Mian was lying on her desk sleeping.

If Qi Jiao had an inexplicable melancholic and sorrowful temperament, then Chen Mian had an arrogant and unrestrained roguish air about her.

Disdainful of the whole world.

Many of the things she painted were dark-themed. Many people who saw her for the first time only thought she was melancholic.

But only Qi Jiao saw the impatience with the world beneath her melancholic exterior.

The next day, Qi Jiao put a box of imported chocolates in her desk.

During break, Chen Mian bit into that chocolate, frowned and took two more bites, then placed the chocolate on the desk.

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1. "The Storied Life of A.J. Fikry" (《島上書店》, literally "The Island Bookstore") is a novel by Gabrielle Zevin about a bookstore owner on a small island. The Chinese title emphasizes the island bookstore setting. The book's famous quote "No man is an island" was referenced earlier in the story. ↩

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Qi Jiao, who was hunched over her desk doing homework, had been secretly glancing at her. She caught all of Chen Mian's actions in her peripheral vision, feeling scared and anxious. After a moment, Chen Mian carried that box of chocolate over and tossed it on Qi Jiao's desk. Frowning, her voice flat and her manner insufferably arrogant, she said, "This stuff is too gross. So bitter. Don't give me any more."

Qi Jiao felt very sad when she heard this. She sat in her seat as if sitting on pins and needles, not knowing what to do.

Her diary entry that day was also very sad. She said she really hadn't meant to—that box of chocolates was very expensive, a four-digit price.

She even added a line to this diary entry the next morning: 【You made me cry all night, bad Chen Mian. But I still can't bring myself to dislike you.】

But the next day, Chen Mian placed a box of chocolates and a box of milk candies on her desk. During break, Chen Mian said to her, "When you eat things, eat sweet ones. Don't eat that bitter stuff. No wonder you always look like you're at a funeral."

Qi Jiao was in a daze all day because of those words.

And in return, at lunchtime, she bought Chen Mian a chicken drumstick.

At that time, she was eating alone in the cafeteria, and so was Chen Mian.

They had both eaten many meals alone and quietly, but Chen Mian sat in her spot for a long time, not touching her own food tray. Finally, she carried her tray and went to sit across from Qi Jiao.

This was the first time Qi Jiao had someone sitting across from her when eating at school.

Chen Mian wasn't a patient good companion. She spoke little, had a bad temper, and occasionally cursed.

But in Qi Jiao's eyes, she was genuine.

Chen Mian was only quiet when painting. She was born with the talent to be a painter. Her paintings were wild and imaginative, as if free souls were leaping onto the paper.

It was the brush leading her hand to paint, not her holding the brush.

Qi Jiao once asked Chen Mian why she liked painting so much.

Chen Mian said it was because she didn't like talking.

Qi Jiao and Chen Mian were nothing more than simple playmates—at least that's how it was defined in Qi Jiao's diary. She had no other friends, so she could only play with Chen Mian.

Chen Mian would occasionally ignore her, and when Yang Jiani appeared, even if Qi Jiao saw Chen Mian, she would quickly walk away without acknowledging the looks Chen Mian sent her way.

Whether confused or pleasantly surprised.

In a way, they were indeed suited to be playmates.

Both would abandon the other at different times.

Qi Jiao discovered that she liked Chen Mian when Chen Mian started getting close to an upperclassman.

That upperclassman was the daughter of Chen Mian's painting teacher. She was gentle, pretty, and had good temperament. When talking with Chen Mian, Chen Mian would rarely show a shy expression and would occasionally blush.

Qi Jiao had only seen them walking together from afar—beautiful and serene.

The afterglow of the sunset enveloped them, an emotion Qi Jiao would never have in her lifetime.

And Qi Jiao was also caught by Chen Mian secretly watching Liang Shi. The only person Qi Jiao ever confided in was Chen Mian.

The first time she drank alcohol was with Chen Mian. After drinking too much, her face was flushed red. She quietly whispered in Chen Mian's ear, "I have a little sister."

She said her sister was from different parents on both sides¹. Her sister was like a little angel, with a pair of very beautiful light brown eyes. She had a sweet and adorable personality and would sweetly call her "sister."

The diary entry went on here, then the focus shifted back to Liang Shi.

Qi Jiao said Liang Shi's personality had changed now. She could protect herself. This was truly something worth being happy about.

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Qi Jiao's diary was expansive, with all the beautiful brushstrokes reserved for Chen Mian and Liang Shi.

After reading through it once more, Liang Shi pulled out her phone and opened WeChat. She had cleared her contacts once before, so she might have already deleted Chen Mian.

She carefully looked through her list and found a profile picture mixed among the many contacts.

A girl wearing a white dress stood in a hazy moon.

This was a difficult painting to execute—the slightest mistake would make the color contrast look ugly.

But Chen Mian had painted it very well. It was almost identical to the one Chen Mian had given the original owner according to her memories.

And her WeChat name was: J.

The "Jiao" from Qi Jiao.

That was how Liang Shi interpreted it.

She tapped into the chat and sent Chen Mian a message: 【Are you there? Chen Mian.】

She directly called her by name.

A moment later, Chen Mian replied: 【?】

The brief question mark was Chen Mian's typical style.

Liang Shi: 【Are you in Haizhou City? Let's meet.】

Chen Mian: 【I'm in Country Y.】

This single sentence completely blocked off what Liang Shi wanted to say.

She wanted to meet Chen Mian and ask whether Chen Mian understood Qi Jiao's state of mind before she jumped off the building.

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Liang Shi really wanted to know what Qi Jiao had experienced in the days before she chose to jump. The diary entries from that period were all vague and unclear.

Chen Mian's tone was distant. Liang Shi didn't push and sent her: 【Sorry to bother you.】

Attempting to end the conversation with this.

But then Chen Mian said: 【I'm returning to the country next week. Let's meet then.】

Liang Shi immediately replied: 【Okay.】

Chen Mian had never deleted Liang Shi from her WeChat, and she replied quickly to her messages.

It was probably related to Qi Jiao.

Thinking of the recording she had heard, Liang Shi increasingly felt there was something between Qi Jiao and Chen Mian.

It didn't seem quite like what was shown in the diary.

Liang Shi carefully put away Qi Jiao's diary, then drove to the kindergarten. On the way to the kindergarten, a staff member from the "Mo Guang"² production crew called to notify her that her scenes would start filming on Wednesday. She must arrive at the crew by 7 AM on Wednesday to begin hair and makeup.

Liang Shi acknowledged with an okay.

On one hand, she lamented that she hadn't rested a single day since coming here, spinning like a wound-up clock. On the other hand, she thought about how many days were left until her tasks ended.

She felt like these tasks were endless.

Liang Shi waited at the kindergarten entrance for a while and soon it was time for kindergarten to let out.

She saw Su Yao who had come to pick up Sheng Yu, greeted her, and politely inquired about how she was doing.

Su Yao answered each question.

As for Rainbow, she still had no one picking her up. Zhou Li was busy with work and would leave Rainbow at the kindergarten under the supervision of the teacher on duty.

Seeing Rainbow all alone, Liang Shi picked her up too.

When Ling Dang saw it was Liang Shi picking her up, she curiously asked, "Auntie, where's my mommy?"

"I don't know." Liang Shi scooped her up in one motion. "Big Uncle asked me to take you back to the old residence."

Upon hearing the words "old residence," Ling Dang shrank back, somewhat resistant. "Let's... not?"

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1. "Different parents on both sides" (異父異母) means they share neither the same father nor the same mother—in other words, they are not biologically related at all. Qi Jiao considered Liang Shi her "sister" even though they had no blood relation. ⇐
 2. "Mo Guang" (《餘光》) literally means "Lingering Light" or "Peripheral Vision"—this is the name of the drama/film production that Liang Shi is participating in. ⇐